

A It is possible to convert an internal HDD to an external HDD. You need to buy a case which retails for Rs 1,500-2,000. Just put your drive in the case and connect it to your PC with a USB cable. These cases do not support SATA drives—only regular IDE ATA disk drives.

PROcessor CON!

Q I recently bought a PC with an AMD processor 2800+, ASUS motherboard, an 80 GB HDD, 256 MB of DDR RAM, a combo drive etc. I have installed Windows XP. The PC configuration in the device manager displayed “AMD Processor 1500+”. When I asked the vendor about this, he replied about some switches on the motherboard. On changing those, it would show the correct configuration. I am not so familiar with AMD processors. I want to know what the number 1500+ actually means, and is my vendor right?

Earlier I worked on a P IV PC with a VIA chipset motherboard. I had a bad experience with that PC. I came to know that the VIA chipset doesn’t support high-end games. So I didn’t opt for any motherboard having VIA chipsets. But my vendor says that there are no chipsets available other than VIA for AMD processors. When I opened my CPU, I saw that he had given us an ASUS motherboard with a VIA chipset. Now my PC hangs every time I install a game, even a small one like Delta Force. Is it the motherboard, or something else responsible? Aren’t there other motherboards available for AMD computers? Is a graphics card required to install games?

Sambit Mohapatra

A To check whether your vendor has given you the correct processor, go to your BIOS. Your processor’s core speed will be listed there. Alternatively, download any of the following utilities: Sisoft Sandra from <http://www.sisoftware.net/> or Everest from <http://www.lavalys.com/>. Click on the Computer>Summary tab and your system specs will get listed. This will tell you whether you have been taken for a ride.

The term “1500+” is AMD’s way of indicating the processor’s performance—this proces-

sor will give the same performance as an Intel processor running at a core speed of 1500 MHz. This is *not* the actual core speed at which the processor runs. If your processor is an Athlon XP 1500+, then your actual CPU core speed is 1,333 MHz.

There are four chipset manufacturers for AMD boards—ATi, nVidia nForce, SiS and VIA.

There are manufacturers who make motherboards based on these chipsets—ASUS, Gigabyte, MSI and others.

You need a graphics card to play almost all high-end games these days. For specifics, refer to *Digit* (January) for the graphics card shootout. Since you haven’t mentioned your motherboard or the chipset specification, we cannot give you a detailed answer. But you can check your motherboard and graphics card (if you have it) using the SiSoft utility. Also, try installing DirectX9c and update your graphics driver. Try running games now. It might work.

The Infamous BSOD

Q I have a P IV 2.4 GHz PC with 512 MB of DDR RAM, an Intel 865GBF Motherboard, nVidia GeForce FX 5200 AGP, an 80 GB Seagate Barracuda 7,200 RPM, a Samsung combo drive and a Realtek Rtl 8139 ethernet card. When I logon to or logout from Windows XP, the blue screen of death appears often—in fact 80 per cent of the time with either one of these messages:

1. IRQL_NOT_LESS_OR_EQUAL Technical Information: Stop (0x00000000,0x00000002,0x00000000,0x804 D9716)

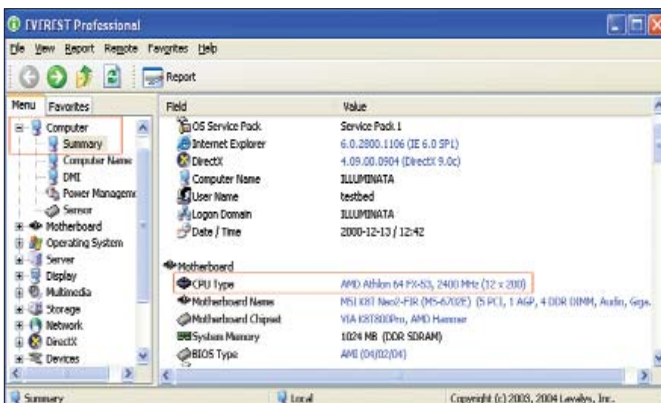
2. PAGEFAULT_IN_NONPAGED_AREA Technical Information: Stop 0x00000050 (0xFFFFF60,0x00000000,0x804F4C32,0x00000000)

The technical information varies each time. The errors occur mainly when I switch from one user account to another (I have disabled faster user switching). I have no problems when I logon immediately after system boot. I have installed the latest BIOS drivers. There are no anti-virus or background software installed. I have Windows XP Professional, Windows 98 SE and SuSe Linux with XOSL in a separate partition. Is there a fault in my RAM?

Amar Gupta

A This error happens mainly due to the hardware or software incompatibility. To avoid this, update the drivers of all your devices and upgrade to SP2 in Windows XP.

If that still does not solve the problem, immediately after you get the error, reboot your PC and see the CPU temperature in the BIOS. In case, it is too high, then your system is overheating and you must get a better heat sink and fan. If the temperature is normal, then go to Start>All Programs>Accessories>System Tools> System Information. Click on IRQ on the left side. View the status of your IRQs in the right hand pane. If there is any IRQ whose status is not OK, uninstall that



Viewing System Summary in Everest